

Saharnaz Babaei-Balderlou

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Labor Economics, Applied Microeconomics, AI & Technology in Education and Work, Workforce Equity, Diversity & Inclusion

ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Lecturer , University of Maryland, College Park	8/2026 - Present
Google Higher Ed Faculty AI Fellow , North America	6/2026 - Present
Teaching Assistant Professor , University of Wisconsin - La Crosse, WI, USA	8/2024 - 8/2026

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Economics , University of South Carolina, Columbia, SC, USA	2018 - 2024
Master of Economics , Urmia University, Urmia, Iran	2011 - 2013
Bachelor of Economics , Urmia University, Urmia, Iran	2007 - 2011

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

- **Babaei-Balderlou, S.**, & Shakya, S. (Forthcoming - 2026) "Can Structured AI Tutoring and Study Groups Improve Learning Outcomes? Evidence from a Randomized Controlled Trial." *Journal of Economic Education*.
- Tran, H., **Babaei-Balderlou, S.**, Vesely, R. (2024). Balancing the Scale: Investigating the Effect of Frontloading and Backloading Salary Structures on Teacher Turnover. *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 152, 104809. ([DOI](#))
- Tran, H., **Babaei-Balderlou, S.**, & Smith, D. A. (2024). The promises and pitfalls of government-funded teacher staffing initiatives on teacher employment in hard-to-staff schools: Evidence from South Carolina. *Policy Futures in Education*, 22(1), 43-65. ([DOI](#))
- Heidari, H., **Babaei Balderlou, S.**, & Ebrahimi Torki, M. (2016). Effects of the Import of Consumption, Intermediate and Capital Goods on Transmission of Crude Oil Price Volatility to the Industry and Mining Sector in Iran. *Journal of Energy Planning And Policy Research*, 2(2), 195-234. (Peer-reviewed; In Persian; [Link](#))
- Heidari, H., **Babaei Balderlou, S.**, & Ebrahimi Torki, M. (2016) Energy Intensity of GDP: A Nonlinear Estimation of Determinants in Iran. *International Journal of Economics and Management Studies (IJEMS)*, 1 (2), 1-19. (Peer-reviewed; [Link](#))
- Heidari, H., & **Babaei-Balderlou, S.** (2014). Investigation of the effect of crude oil price uncertainty on the growth of Industry and Mine sector in Iran: An application of Markov-Switching Models. *Quarterly Energy Economics Review*, 10(41), 43-70. (Peer-reviewed; In Persian; [Link](#))
- Heydari, H., & **Babaei, S.** (2013). Crude oil price contagion to the growth of Industry and Mine sector in Iran: An approach to Markov-Switching Models. *Iranian Journal of Energy*, 16(3), 0-0. (Peer-reviewed; In Persian; [Link](#))

Last Updated: September 2, 2026

WORKING PAPERS

- Fostering Equity: How Employment Anti-Discrimination Policies Shape Teacher Satisfaction and Retention, with Tran, H. [[Link](#)]
- Cash Incentives or Token Gestures? Teacher Incentive Bonuses in North Carolina, with Maloney, S. [[Link](#)]

WORK IN PROGRESS

- Integration of Gen-AI into Higher Education, with Shakya, S.
- Wage Analysis in AI-Exposed Occupations, with Brekke, A.
- Policy to Practice Pathways: Policy Strictness and School Climate.
- Unpacking the Mechanisms of Anti-Discrimination Policies on Workforce Stability
- Limitations of Mental Health Services for K-12 Public Schools, with Schultz, B. K.
- Discrimination perception at workplace, with Tran, H.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Maryland, College Park

College Park, MD, USA

Lecturer

2026 - Present

- **Economics of Big Data** – *In Person, Fall 2026*
[Link to evaluations](#): Forthcoming
- **Money & Banking** – *In Person, Fall 2026*
[Link to evaluations](#): Forthcoming
- **Principles of Macroeconomics** – *In Person, Fall 2026*
[Link to evaluations](#): Forthcoming

College of Business Administration, University of Wisconsin - La Crosse

La Crosse, WI, USA

Assistant Teaching Professor

2024 - 2026

- **Data Analysis for Business Applications** – (4 sections) – *In Person, Spring 2026*
[Link to evaluations](#): 55–83% participation
- **Data Analysis for Business Applications** – (1 sections) – *Online, Winter 2026*
[Link to evaluations](#): 18.2% participation
- **Data Analysis for Business Applications** – (4 sections) – *In Person, Fall 2025*
[Link to evaluations](#): 76–86% participation
- **Global Macroeconomics** – (4 sections) – *In Person, Spring 2025*
[Link to evaluations](#): 63–86% participation
- **Global Macroeconomics** – (4 sections) – *In Person, Fall 2024*
[Link to evaluations](#): 74–94% participation

Darla Moore School of Business, University of South Carolina

Columbia, SC, USA

Primary Instructor

2021 - 2024

- **Principles of Microeconomics** – *In Person, Spring 2024*
[Link to evaluations](#): 4.2/5.0 (80% participation)
- **Introduction to Economics** – *In Person, Spring 2023*
[Link to evaluations](#): 4.5/5.0 (67% participation)
- **Introduction to Economics** – *In Person, Spring 2022*
[Link to evaluations](#): 3.7/5.0 (70% participation)
- **Introduction to Economics** – *Online, Spring 2021*
[Link to evaluations](#): 4.3/5.0 (61% participation)

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE AND MEDIA RECOGNITION

Media and Public Engagement

- Referenced at Higher Ed AI Playbook by Dr. Aviva Legatt [Link to Article](#)
- Published Article at [TheConversation.com](#), We designed an AI tutor that helps college students reason rather than give them answers, (2025). DOI: [10.64628/AAI.vppxk3t6x](#)
- Invited interview on teacher labor markets and compensation policy, *Faculti* (2025). DOI: [10.5321/12345](#)

Mentorship and Advising

- Faculty Mentor, Eagle Apprenticeship Program for Undergraduate Research, UWL 2025 – 2026
- Certified Academic Master Advisor, UWL 2025 – 2026
- Mentor, Undergraduate Honors Student Research Project, USC 2022 – 2024

Peer Review and Conference Engagement

- Reviewer, *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization (JEBO)*
- Reviewer, *Journal of Economic Education (JEE)*
- Reviewer, *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis (EEPA)*
- Reviewer, *Administrative Sciences*
- Reviewer, *Education Sciences*
- Reviewer, *Societies*
- Reviewer, *Social Sciences*
- Reviewer, Cambridge University Press (Introductory Economics Textbook)
- Program Reviewer, *APPAM Research Conference* 2025 - 2026
- Conference Roles (Reviewer / Presenter / Discussant):
 - AEA Conference on Teaching and Research in Economic Education (CTREE) 2026
 - Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (APPAM) Annual Conference 2023 - 2026
 - American Economic Association Conference on Teaching and Research in Economic Education 2026
 - Population Association of America (PAA) Annual Conference 2024
 - National Economics Teaching Association (NETA) 2025
 - Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting 2022–2025
 - Eastern Economic Association (EEA), CSWEP Session 2024
 - Western Economic Association International (WEAI) 2023
 - Carolina Region Empirical Economics Day (CREED) 2021, 2023
 - International Energy Conferences, Tehran 2012, 2014

Workshops and Professional Development

- Guest Workshop Leader, *WiSys Innovation On-Ramp Program*, UW-La Crosse Fall 2025
- Certification for Mathematics for Machine Learning and Data Science Specialization by DeepLearning.AI on Coursera. [Link to the Certificate](#) Summer 2025
- Completed the *UW MBA Consortium Online Instructor Certification (iCC)*, UW MBA Summer 2025
- Multimodal Machine Learning Pipeline – AIAI 2025 Competition:
 - Designed and executed a full-scale segment-level classification pipeline for educational videos using BERT and VideoMAE on HPC infrastructure;
 - Implemented automated QC, multimodal feature alignment, and optimized model thresholds.
- Certification of Statistical Learning with Python, StanfordOnline by Stanford University 2024
- Certification of R Programming A-Z: R for Data Science by Udemy 2024
- Certification of the Complete SQL Bootcamp: From Zero to Hero by Udemy 2024
- Workshop Leader, *LaTeX for Economics Ph.D. Students*, University of South Carolina Fall 2023
- Workshop Leader, *Job Market Preparation for Ph.D. Candidates*, U of SC 2023
- Certification of *Preparing Future Faculty*, by the Center for Teaching Excellence, U of SC 2018–2024
- Certification of SHARPGad (Skills, Habits, and Research Productivity) by U of SC 2021
- Workshop Participant, Preventing Harassment and Discrimination Training by U of SC 2021
- Workshop Participant, *Modern Meta-Analysis Workshop*, NSF, AERA, ICPSR, AIR PEERS Data Hub 2021
- Workshop Participant, *Meta-Analysis and Systematic Reviews*, CARMA Short Course 2021

Other University and Departmental Service

- IAS Annual Review Committee, UWL Fall 2025
- Scholarship Reviewer, *UWL Alumni and Friends Foundation*, UWL 2024 - 2026
- Representative, [Scholar Day](#), UW-La Crosse 2024 - 2026
- Committee Member, Department of Economics Recruitment Initiative, UW-La Crosse Fall 2024

FELLOWSHIPS AND HONORS

Google Higher Ed Faculty AI Fellow, Google for Education / Canopy Education, North America Cohort	2026
Annual Performance Review: Rated “Significant Merit” (Highest Level), UWL	2024-2025
Humane Studies Graduate Fellowship (\$2,000), Institute for Humane Studies (IHS)	2023
SPARC Graduate Research Grant (\$5,000), University of South Carolina	2023
Moore School Research Grant (\$2,545), Darla Moore School of Business, USC	2023
Graduate Research Assistantship, Wardlaw College of Education, USC	2019–2024
Graduate Assistantship, Darla Moore School of Business, USC	2018–2019

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- Research Assistant, Supervisor: Dr. Henry Tran** **Columbia, SC, USA**
Wardlaw College of Education, University of South Carolina 2019 - 2024
- Assistance in conceptualization, design and planning, data curation, empirical analysis, visualization, and dissemination of academic research papers
 - Applied econometrics causal inference methods
- Research Assistant, Multiple Projects** **Columbia, SC, USA**
Darla Moore School of Business, University of South Carolina 2018 - 2019
- Assistance in data collection, curation, and cleaning in multiple projects by Dr. Bentley Coffey, Dr. Crystal Zhan, and Dr. Joshua Hess
- Research Assistant, Supervisor: Professor Hassan Heidari** **Urmia, Iran**
School of Economic and Management Sciences, Urmia University 2013-2016
- Data collection and analysis for spatial planning in West Azerbaijan, Iran

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Econometrics:** Causal inference, panel data, cross-sectional and time-series analysis, heteroskedasticity modeling (univariate/multivariate GARCH models), meta-analysis
- **Statistical Tools:** R, Python, STATA
- **Data & Visualization Tools:** Tableau, SQL, ArcGIS
- $\text{\LaTeX}$
- **Languages:** English (Fluent), Persian (Native), Azerbaijani-Turkish (Native)

MEMBERSHIPS

- Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (APPAM)
- Population Association of America (PAA)
- American Economic Association (AEA)
- National Economics Teaching Association (NETA)

REFERENCES

Primary Ph.D. Advisors

Yi Crystal Zhan, Ph.D.

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Ph.D. Committee Members and Collaborators

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Henry Tran, Ph.D.

Ph.D. Committee Member and Research Supervisor
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Professional References (Current Institution)

Sheida Babakhani Teimouri, Ph.D.

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